

About the Cabbala
Explanations of Rudolf Steiner

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Foreword

Explanations of Rudolf Steiner consist only of quotations and are located between GANNN, where NNN is the number of the complete edition.

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GA089

About the Cabbala, 18 March 1904, Berlin

We have seen that the Bible can be more and more deeply understood the more we penetrate into theosophical teaching. Today, however, you will see how theosophy, theosophical wisdom, existed for millennia, merely having different names, words and so on at different times. Today's brief outline will be of something which was taught among the Jews of old. Today, the Cabbala¹⁰⁰ is something the profound wisdom of which is little understood even among Jews. It will sometimes emerge where you would least expect it. If you were to meet a learned Jew coming from furthest Galicia, who does not take much care with how he looks, so that he may look repulsive to civilized people, you may find that he still knows something of cabbalistic wisdom. In Austria these people are called 'miracle rabbis' for they have some knowledge of magical arts, being able to use suggestion much more effectively than our modern physicians do, for example. They are also initiated to a certain degree.

Let me first of all say something about what is written in the Cabbala. You will find it said in my Theosophy that the occult teaching in the Cabbala agrees with the things taught in theosophy.

The Cabbala distinguishes twelve principles in the world, the first and last of which remain secret because they cannot be put into words at all.¹⁰¹ Only the other ten are put in words. They are divided into three groups. Firstly, the 'spirit world', the world of purely spiritual entities, secondly the world of the soul, and thirdly the world of bodily nature.

A Cabbalist will immediately say to each of his students: 'You will never see one of these three worlds with your eyes, for at any time you can only see the "realm".' The 'realm' is our own world around us.¹⁰² I see a person, the Cabbala student will say, but what I am seeing is in the 'realm'. In reality this human being is in the threefold world. He has body, soul and spirit. Through the body he breathes and feeds himself; through the soul he feels, and through the spirit he thinks. All this presents itself to us as a whole, as the 'realm'. This is the tenth of the principles. This tenth principle is something in which the other nine come together in many different ways.

Firstly, the world of the bodily principle. This also has three parts. Every body is in itself. If it were not in itself, it would not exist at all. If you come up against it, you perceive its solid state. If it comes up to

you, you perceive its appearance. Thus distinction is made between fundament, solidity, appearance. These are the three sephiroth¹⁰³ of bodily nature. We now have four sephiroth:

realm (10) solidity (9) fundament (8) appearance (7)

Secondly: soul world. Again three sephiroth. The first is what we now call sympathy in theosophy; the Cabbala calls it love. Love is what the soul body gives off when it comes to another. Just as solidity comes to me from another body, so love is what I give out. 6

The second of these sephiroth is grace. This is not merely giving out, like love; it is more held in; it does not give itself the way love does, but gives something 5 to the outside from inside.

The third sephiroth is justice, which merely balances 4 things out.

Those are the three soul sephiroth.

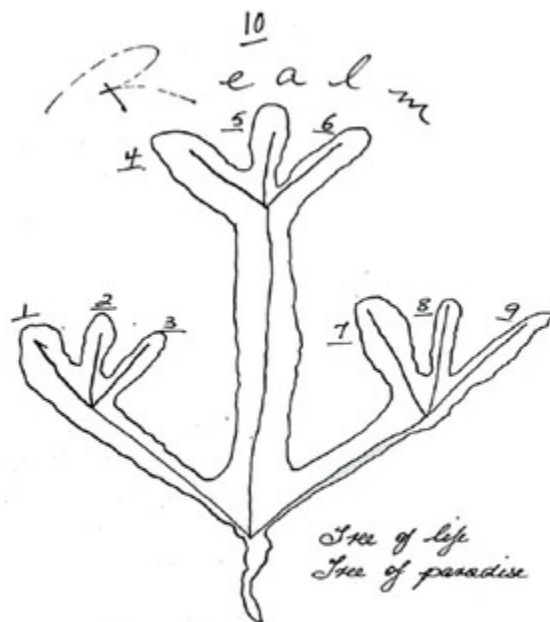
Now for the sephiroth of the spirit world. They are the principle which is truly active.

The first is called 'world mind' in the Cabbala 3

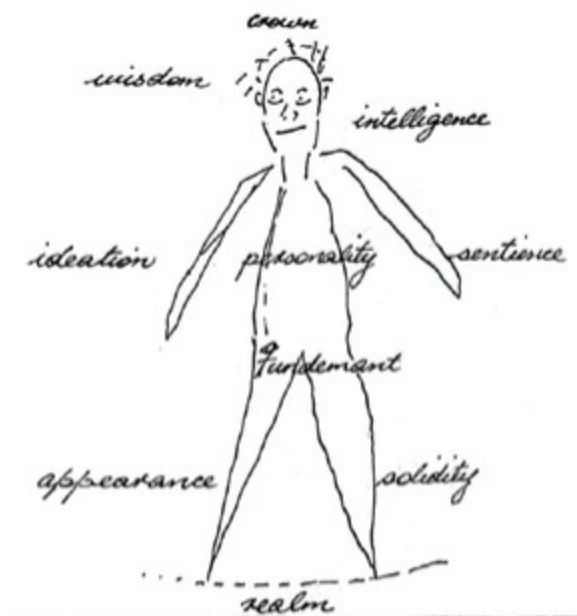
The second the 'world thought', the mind which has 2 the thought

The third is the basic sephiroth, called the 'height' or 'crown' by Cabbalists (kether - the height). 1

These are the ten sephiroth. The Cabbalist then says to his student: you have part of each of these worlds in you. From the bodily world you have the vegetative soul (nephesh), plant soul, etheric double body. From the soul world you have the passion soul, the sentient soul (ruach), and from the spirit land you have the thinking soul (neshamah). These are the bare bones of Jewish occult teaching.



10 sephiroth are the nine branches together with the Realm in paradise.

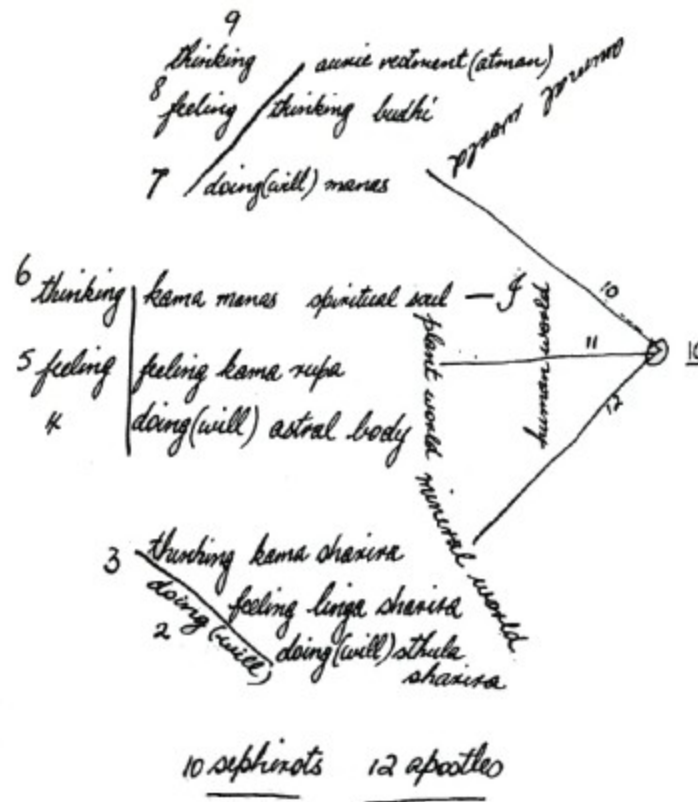


The tree of life is the sum of sephiroths, i.e.

Adam Cadmon / Ram Bull Twins
⊗ ⊗ ⊕

Tree of life
 Tree of paradise
 10 Sephiroth are die nien branches together
 with the realm in paradise.

Wisdom Crown Intelligence
 Ideation Personality Sentence
 Appearance Fundament Solidity
 Realm
 The Tree of life is the sum of
 Sephiroths i.e.
 Adam Cadmon / Ram Bull Twins



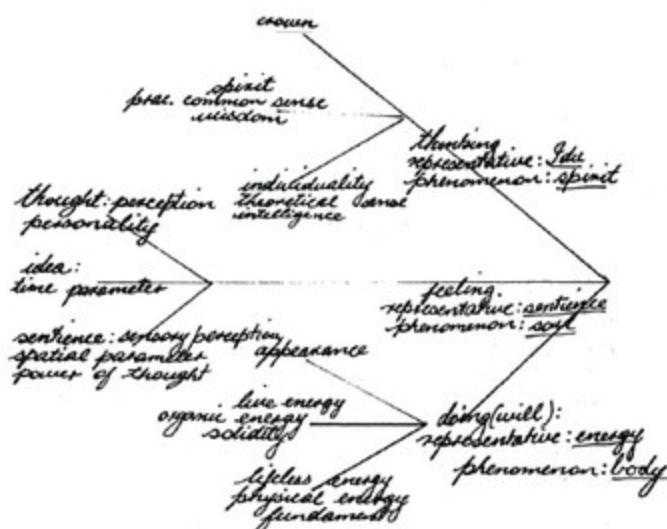
Human world (10)

Animal world (10): Thinking (9), Feeling (8), (7) / Vagina aurica (Atma), Thinking Budhi, Will Manas

Plant world (11): Thinking (6), Feeling (5), (4) / Kamamano – Spiritaul soul – I, Feeling Kamarupa, Will Astral body

Mineral world (12): (3), Will (2), (1) / Thinking Karana Sharira, Feeling Linga Sharira, Will Sthula Sharira

10 Sephirots 12 Apostels



Crown	Thinking
Spirit	Representative: I
Common sense	Phenomenon: Spirit
Wisdom	
Individuality	
Theoretical sense	
Intelligence	
Thought: Perception	Feeling
Personality	Representative: Sentience
Idea: Pleasure Displeasure	Phenomenon: Soul
Time parameter	
Sentience: Perception	
Spatial parameter	
Gedankenkraft	Will
Appearance	Representative: Energy
Life energy	Phenomenon: Body
Organic energy	
Solidity	
Lifeless energy	
Physical energy	
Fundament	

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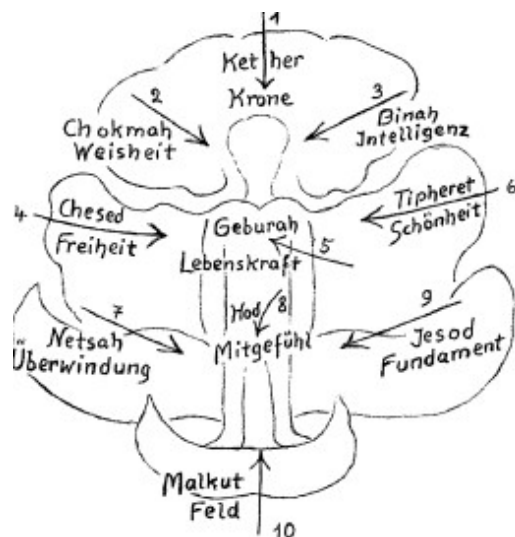
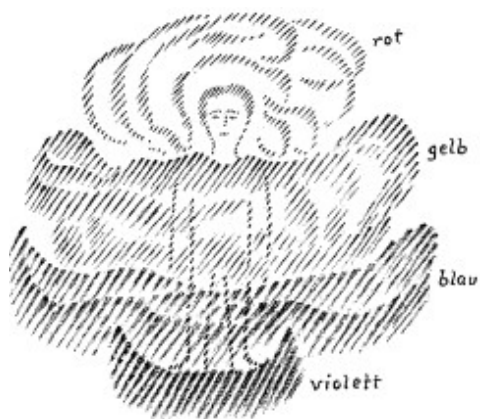
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Lecture 10. 10 May 1924, Dornach

About the Sephirot Tree

Well, gentlemen, we still have the last questions left over from the Jewish Sephiroth tree. In this Sephiroth tree, the Jews of antiquity actually enclosed their highest wisdom. And one could say: they enclosed in it the wisdom of the relationship between man and the world. We have often emphasized that the human being does not only consist of the visible parts that can be seen with the eye, but that the human being also consists of invisible, supersensible members. We have called these supersensible members the etheric body, the astral body, the ego or the ego organization. Now, all these things were known in ancient times, not in the way we have today, but people knew about them instinctively. This ancient knowledge has been completely lost. And today we believe that something like this Jewish Tree of Life, the Sephiroth Tree, is actually a fantasy. But it is not.

Now let us try to understand what the ancient Jews actually meant by this Sephiroth tree. They thought of it like this: Man stands there in the world, but the forces of the world act on him from all sides. If you look at man as he stands in the world (it is drawn), we can imagine him schematically drawn. This is how we imagine a material human being standing in the world. The ancient Jews imagined that the forces of the world were acting on him from all sides. Here I draw an arrow that goes into the heart: Thus the forces of the world act on man; here below the power of the earth.



Now the Jews have said: First of all, three forces act on the human head – I have indicated these in the drawing with these arrows: 1, 2, 3 – three forces on the human center, on the chest, on breathing and blood circulation mainly (arrows 4, 5, 6 of the drawing). Then three more forces act on the limbs of the human being (arrows 7, 8, 9), and a tenth force, which acts on the human being from the earth (arrow 10, from below). So ten forces, the ancient Jews imagined, act on the human being from the outside.

Let us first consider the three forces that come, so to speak, from the farthest parts of the universe and act on the human head, actually making the human head round, like an image of the whole round universe. These three forces, 1, 2, 3, are the noblest; they come, so to speak, if you want to use a later expression, with a Greek expression, for example, from the highest heavens. They shape the human head by making it a round image of the whole round universe.

Now, however, we must develop a concept at the same time, which could disturb you if I simply tell you. You see, in these ten concepts that the Jews have placed at the pinnacle of their wisdom, the first one at the top (1) has been terribly misused; for later, those people who succeeded in seizing power dragged the symbols of that power and the words for that power down into the outer realm of power. And so certain people who have appropriated the power of the nations and transferred it to their descendants have appropriated what is called a crown. In ancient times, a crown was a word for the highest spiritual gift that could be bestowed on a person. And the crown could only be worn by someone who, as I have explained to you, had gone through initiation, that is, someone who had attained the highest wisdom. It was a sign of the highest wisdom. I have already explained to you how the orders originally all meant something, but how they were later created out of vanity and no longer meant anything. In particular, however, we must consider this in relation to the term 'crown'. For the ancients, the crown was the epitome of all that superhumanity from the spiritual world has to bestow upon humanity. No wonder that the kings placed the crown on their heads. They were, as you know, not always wise and did not always have the highest gifts of heaven united in them, but they placed the sign on their heads. And when something like this is spoken according to ancient customs, it must not be confused with what has become of it through misuse. So the highest, the highest gifts of the world, the highest gifts of the spirit, which can descend upon man, which he can unite with his head when he knows much, that was called Kether, the crown, in ancient Judaism. Now, you see, that was the highest. That was what spiritually formed the head from the universe.

And then this human head still needed two other forces. These two other forces came to it from the right and from the left. It was thought: the highest comes down from above; from the right and left come the two other forces, the two world forces, which are spread throughout the universe. Now, the one that goes in through the right ear was called Chokmah = wisdom. Today, if we wanted to translate the word, we would say: wisdom. And on the other side, from the world, came in: Binah. Today we would say: intelligence (2 and 3 of the drawing). The ancient Jews distinguished between wisdom and intelligence. Today, every person who is intelligent is also considered to be wise. But that is not the case. One can be intelligent and think the greatest stupidity. The greatest stupidities are thought up very intelligently. In particular, when one looks at much of today's science, one has to say that this science is actually intelligent in all fields, but it is certainly not wise. The ancient Jews distinguished Chokmah and Binah, the ancient wisdom, from the ancient intelligence at an early stage. So the human head, everything that actually belongs to the sensory system in the human being, and also the nerves that are spread out in the sensory system, all this was designated by the three terms Kether, Chokmah, Binah - crown, wisdom, intelligence.

Thus, according to the view of the ancient Jews, the human head is constructed from the universe. There was therefore a strong awareness - otherwise such a doctrine would not have been developed - that man is a member of the whole universe. We can ask, for example, about the human body: What about the liver? Well, the liver gets its veins from the blood circulation; it gets its strength from the human environment. The ancient Jews said: Man receives the forces from the environment, which then, first in the mother's womb and later, cause his head to develop.

Now, there are three other forces (4, 5, 6 in the drawing); these have more of an effect on the middle person, on the person in whom the heart is, in whom the lungs are. So they have an effect on the middle person; they come down less from above, they live more in the environment. They live in the sunshine that moves around on the earth, they live in wind and weather. The three forces that the ancient Jews mentioned come into consideration here: chesed, geburah, tiphereth. If we want to express this in today's terms, we could say: chesed = freedom; geburah = strength; tiphereth = beauty.

Let us start here with the middle power, with Geburah. I have told you that I want to draw the arrow in such a way that it goes into the heart! The power that man has, this heartiness, soul power and physical power at the same time, is indicated by the human heart. This is how the Jews imagined it: When the breath enters a person, when the breath enters the heart, not only the physical breathing forces enter from the outside, but also the spiritual power, Geburah, which is connected with the breath. We would therefore say, if we wanted to express it more precisely: the life force, the force through which he can also do something = Geburah. But on the one side of Geburah is what was called Chesed, human freedom. And on the other side is Tiphereth, beauty. Man is indeed the most beautiful thing on earth in his form! The old Jew imagined: "When I hear the heartbeat, I hear the life force that comes into man. When I stretch out my right hand, I feel that I am a free man; when the muscles stretch, the power of freedom comes. The left hand, which moves more gently and can grasp more gently, brings what a person does in beauty.

So these three forces: Chesed = freedom, Geburah = vitality, Tiphereth = beauty, correspond to that in man which is connected with breathing and blood circulation, with everything that is in motion and always repeats itself. The movement of sleeping, the change between day and night, also belongs to this. This also belongs to the movement; man also belongs to this.

But then, humans are also beings that can change their position in space, that can walk around, that do not have to stay in one place like plants. The animal can also walk around. Man has this in common

with the animal. The animal has no Chokmah, no Tiphereth, nor Chesed, but it does have Geburah = life force. And the three that I have described, man has in common with the animal only in that he has the others.

This, that one can go around, that one is not bound to one place, the Jews called: Netsah, and that means that one overcomes the firmness of the earth, that one moves (arrow 7 of the drawing). Netsah is overcoming. Now, the one that has more effect on the center of the human being, where his center of gravity is - it is interesting, you know: that is the point, which is located here; it is slightly higher in the waking state and lowers in the sleeping state, which also testifies that there is something outside when we are sleeping - that which works in the center of the body, which also brings about reproduction in humans, which is therefore connected with sexuality, the ancient Jews called Hod. Today we would describe it with a word that would express something like compassion. You see, the expressions are already becoming more human. So Netsah refers to the outer movement - we go out into space - and Hod refers to the inner feeling, the inner movement, the inner compassion with the outer world, that is all Hod (arrow 8). Then under 9: Jesod; this is now the one on which the human being actually stands, the foundation. The human being thus feels bound to the earth; the fact that he can stand on the earth is the foundation, is Jesod. That he has such a foundation also comes from the forces that approach him from outside.

And then the forces of the earth itself work on him (Arrow 10), not only the surrounding forces, but the forces of the earth itself work on him. This was then called Malkuth. We would translate it today as: the field in which the human being works, the earthly outside world; Malkuth - the field. It is difficult to find the right expression for this Malkuth. One could say: realm, field; but all things have actually been misused, and today's names no longer describe what the old Jew felt: that the earth actually has an effect on him.

We need only imagine that we have the center of the human being here; a thigh bone begins on each side of the human being - this goes up to the knee, where the kneecaps would be. All these forces also act on these bones; but the fact that it is actually pierced like this, that it is actually a tube, is due to the penetration of the earthly forces. So everything where the earthly forces penetrate, that is what the old Jew called Malkuth, the field.

So you see, you have to get close to people if you want to talk about this Sephiroth tree! The Jews called the ten Sephiroth together: Kether, Chokmah, Binah, Chesed, Geburah, Tiphereth, Netsah, Hod, Jesod, Malkuth. These ten forces are what actually connects man with the higher, with the spiritual world. Only the tenth power, Malkuth, is sunk into the earth. So basically, this is the physical human being (pointing to the drawing), and the spiritual human being surrounds this physical human being, first as the earth forces below, but then as the forces that are already closer to the earth, but still work in from the surroundings: Netsah, Hod, Jesod. So all of this belongs spiritually to man, as these forces take effect. Then there are the forces that affect his blood circulation and breathing: Chesed, Geburah, Tiphereth. And then the noblest forces that affect man, that affect his brain system: Kether, Chokmah, Binah. So that the Jews actually thought of man as connected with the world on all sides, as I have colorfully depicted for you here. Man is indeed such that he also contains a supersensible element within him. And they imagined this supersensible element in this way.

But now we can raise the question: What else did the Jews actually want to achieve with the ten sephirot, that they used to explain man's relationship to the world? Every Jewish pupil had to learn the ten sephirot, but not just so that he could list them; you would have a completely false idea if you thought that the teaching in the old Jewish schools was such that the main thing I have drawn on the

board was the most striking thing. If one only wants to answer the question, "What is the Sephiroth tree?" one could quickly have finished it; you would have known it in a flash. People today are satisfied with asking, "What is the Sephiroth tree?" This and that is in it, what I have told you now. But that is not in relation to man! Instead, they just give you ten words and all kinds of fanciful explanations for them! But in relation to the human being, what I have told you is the right thing. But that was not the end of it in schools; rather, the Jewish pupil who was to learn science in the sense of the time had to learn much more about it.

Just imagine, gentlemen, you had only learned what the alphabet is and you would know if someone asked you: What is A, B, C, D and so on? - so the letters A, B, C, D and so on. You would have been able to list the twenty-two or twenty-three letters in a row. You wouldn't be able to do much with that! If any man could only enumerate the twenty-three letters, he could not do much with them, could he? But an ancient Jew who could only say: Kether, Chokmah, Binah, Chesed, Geburah, Tiphereth, Netsah, Hod, Jesod, Malkuth, so these ten Sephiroth could have enumerated, would have been regarded just the same. Anyone who had only answered in this way would have seemed to the Jews like someone who could say: A, B, C, D, E, F, G, H and so on. You have to learn more than just the alphabet, don't you; you have to learn to use the alphabet to read, you have to learn how to use the letters to read. Now, gentlemen, just think about how few letters there are and how much you have already read in your life! You just have to consider that. Take any book, take, I mean, for example, Karl Marx's "Capital" and look at it when you have the book in front of you: there is nothing on the pages but the twenty-two letters, nothing else! There are only the letters in it in the book. But what is inside is a lot, and it is all produced by the fact that the twenty-two letters are jumbled up: sometimes the A is before the B, sometimes before the M, sometimes the M before the A, the L before the I and so on, and that's how the whole complicated thing in the book comes about. If someone only knows the alphabet, he picks up the book and perhaps says: I understand everything in the book: there is A, B, C, only arranged differently; I know everything in the book. But he cannot read everything that is really written there inwardly, according to the meaning. You see, one must learn to read with what the letters are; one must really be able to jumble the letters in one's head and mind in such a way that meaning arises from them. And so the ancient Jews had to learn the ten sephiroth; for them, they were letters. You will say: Yes, they are words. But in the beginning, letters were also designated by words! This was only lost by the people when the letters came to Europe, in Greece.

It was not until the transition from Greek to Roman culture that something very significant happened. The Greeks called their A not A, but Alpha, and Alpha actually means: the spiritual man; and they called their B not B, but Beta, that is something like a house. And so every letter had a name. And the Greek could not have imagined that the letter is something else than what is called by a name. It was only when the transition from Greek culture to Roman culture took place that people no longer said Alpha, Beta, Gamma, Delta and so on. They no longer referred to the letters by their names, where each name indicated what such a letter meant. Instead, they said: A, B, C, D and so on, and the whole thing became abstract. Just as Greek culture was dying out and merging with Roman culture, the great cultural diarrhea began in Europe. In the midst of this huge diarrhea, the spiritual aspect of the path from Greek to Roman culture was lost.

And you see, Judaism was particularly great then. When they wrote down their Aleph, their first letter, they meant the human being. Aleph is that. They knew: wherever they placed this letter for the sensual world, what they expressed with this letter must apply to the human being. And so each letter that represented the expressions of the material world also had a name. And the names: Kether, Chokmah, Binah, Chesed, Geburah, Tiphereth, Netsah, Hod, Jesod, Malkuth, were the names for the spiritual letters, for that which one had to learn in order to read in the spiritual world. And so the Jews had one

alphabet: Aleph, Beth, Gimel and so on - an alphabet with which they grasped the outer world, the physical world. But they also had the other alphabet, where they had only ten letters, ten Sephiroth, and with that they grasped the spiritual world.

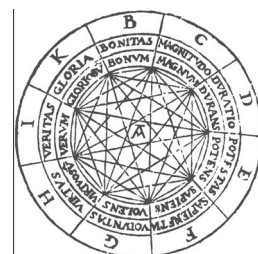
You see, gentlemen, when I list the names for you, Kether, Chokmah, Binah, Chesed and so on, well, that's like A, B, C, D and so on. But then such an old Jew would have known how to say, as we jumble the letters, Kether, Chesed, Binah. And if he had said: Kether, Chesed, Binah, if he had rolled the dice like that, he would have said: In the spiritual world, the highest spiritual power brings about intelligence through freedom. - And with that he would have designated the higher beings who do not have a physical body, in whom the highest power of heaven brings about intelligence through freedom.

Or he would have said: Chokmah, Geburah, Malkuth - that would have meant: Through wisdom, the spirits bring forth the life force through which they work on earth. - He knew how to jumble all these things together like we jumble letters. So these disciples of the ancient Jews understood spiritual science in their own way through these ten spiritual letters. This tree, the Sephiroth tree, was therefore the same for them as the tree of the alphabet with its twenty-three letters is for us. These things have developed in a very strange way, you see: in the first two centuries after the emergence of Christianity, people knew about all these things. But when the Jews were scattered throughout the world, this way of knowing through the ten Sephiroth was also scattered. Individual Jewish students, who, as you may know, were then called Chachamim when they became students of the rabbi, these Chachamim still learned these things; but even there it was no longer really known how to read through these ten Sephiroth. For example, in the 12th century, a great dispute arose over two sentences; the first sentence was called: Hod, Chesed, Binah. Maimonides held on to this sentence. His opponent, on the other hand, claimed: Chesed, Kether, Binah. So people were already arguing about these sentences. You have to know: These sentences are derived from the Sephiroth tree; one person read it this way, another that, and put the elements together in different ways. But this art of reading had actually been forgotten since the Middle Ages. And the interesting thing is that later, in the middle of the Middle Ages, a man appeared, Raimundus Lullus – a very interesting person, this Raimundus Lullus!

You see, gentlemen, getting to know a person like that is actually extremely interesting. Imagine there was someone among you who was quite curious. He would say to himself: Now that I've heard about Raimund Lullus, I want to read up on him! First, take the encyclopedia, but then take any books that mention Raimund Lullus: Yes, if you read what is written about Raimund Lullus in today's books, you will split your sides laughing, because he would have been the most ridiculous person you could ever imagine! People say: This Raimundus Lullus, he wrote ten words on pieces of paper, and then he took something like you have in a game of hazard, a kind of roulette, where you spin, where you jumble up the story, and he would have always jumbled up these ten pieces of paper, and what would have come out, he would have written down, and that would have been his world wisdom. Well, when you read something like that, that words were simply written on ten pieces of paper and mixed up, and the man wanted to find something special by doing that, you have to hold your sides laughing, because it's a ridiculous person who would do something like that.

Ars magna, Fig. 1 Great art, Fig. 1

B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	K
Bonitas	Magnitudo	Duratio	Potentas	Sapientia	Voluntas	Virtus	Veritas	Gloria
Goodness	Greatness	Duration	Power	Wisdom	Will	Virtue	Truth	Glory
Bonum	Magnum	Durans	Potens	Sapiens	Volens	Virtuosus	Verum	Gloriosus
Good	Great	Lasting	Powerful	Wise	Willing	Virtuous	True	Glorious



But that was not the case with Raimundus Lullus. He actually said the following: You can still go as far as you like with all that your earthly alphabet gives you, but you still cannot find the truth. And now he said: Your ordinary head is not good enough to find the truth. This ordinary head is like a roulette wheel that you spin, but there is nothing in it, so nothing can be found to win. Lullus told his fellow human beings: You have actually all become empty-headed, your head is nothing more, there is nothing more in it. And you must put such concepts as these ten sephiroth into your heads one day; you must learn to turn your heads from one of the sephiroth to the other until you learn to use the letters. That is what Raimundus Lullus told them. It is also written in his writings. He only used a picture for it, and the philosophers took the picture seriously and believed that he really meant a kind of roulette where you turn around to mix the tickets, while this roulette that he meant is supposed to be the supersensible recognition in the mind!

This Tree of Life, this Sephiroth Tree, is therefore the spiritual alphabet. People who lived in the West, in Greece, had a spiritual alphabet even in ancient times. And in the time of Alexander the Great and Aristotle, ten concepts were also given there in the Greek way. You can still find them today in all school logics: Being, property, relationship, and so on, and also ten such names, only that they are different because they are suitable for the West. But in the West these ten Greek letters of the spiritual alphabet have been understood just as little as the ones mentioned before.

But you see, it is actually quite an interesting story that is taking place in humanity. Over in Asia, those who still knew something learned to read in the spiritual world through this Sephiroth tree. And in the first centuries of Christianity, people who still knew something about the spiritual world learned to read according to the Aristotelian Tree of Life - over in Greece, in Rome and so on. But gradually everyone – those of the Sephiroth Tree and those of the Aristotle Tree – forgot what these things actually are, and could only list the ten terms. And now we simply have to use these things in such a way that we learn to read in the spiritual world, otherwise little by little people will be forgotten. You see, the following is a very interesting sentence. When a Jewish sage wrote or said: Geburah, Netsah, Hod, one would have to translate today as follows in German: the life-force hatches the dreams in the kidneys. But when one says today: the life-force hatches the dreams in the kidneys, one means physical forces, physical effects. But when the ancient Jew said Geburah, Netsah, Hod, he meant that what is in man as a spiritual being brings about what appears in dreams. Everywhere it was a spiritual assertion that was expressed by what arose from the random throwing together of the letters.

It is indeed only through spiritual science that it is possible today to get any information about these things. Because no one will tell you today that these ten sephiroth were such letters for the spiritual world. You won't hear it anywhere else, no one really knows it today! So you can say that the situation is such that today's science no longer knows most of the things that were once known in humanity, and they must first be regained.

Take this letter that I have drawn for you here: Aleph 8. What does this Aleph mean for the sensory world? Well, it represents a person. This is how he stands, sending out his power. That is this line (drawing). He raises his right hand: that is this line; he stretches out the other hand: that is this line. So this first letter Aleph expresses man. And every letter expressed something – even in Greek – just as the first letter expresses “man”.

You see, gentlemen, today people no longer have any sense of how things are connected. The first letter for man was called Aleph by the Hebrews, Alpha by the Greeks, and by this they meant what moves spiritually in man, what is spiritual behind the physical man. But now you also have an old German

word. First of all, it is used when a person has special dreams. When a spiritual person presses him, then this is called the nightmare, the nightmare. One says that something comes over the person that possesses him. But then, from nightmare, emerged elf, and then elf, the elf - these spiritual beings, the elves; the human being is only a condensed elf. The word Elf, which goes back to Alp, may still remind you of Alpha in Greek. You only have to omit the A to get Alph – ph is the same as our F – a spiritual being. Because the F has been added, we say: the Aleph in man, the Alp in man. If you omit the vowels everywhere, as is customary in Jewish, you get directly Alph = EIf for the first letter. People pronounce: Elf for this spiritual being. One speaks of elves. Of course, today one says: These are beings that the ancients invented out of their imagination. We no longer believe in it. But the ancients said: You only need to look at the human being itself to see the alph. The alph is just inside the body, and it is not a fine, ethereal being, but a dense physical being inside the human being. But people have long since forgotten how to understand the human being.

And so you experience the most droll thing, gentlemen. Just imagine that in the second half of the 19th century the following came about - I don't want to say anything against it, such things can happen -: a table was taken, people sat around it, let's say eight people; they place their hands, which then touch at the outermost ends, on the table top, and then the table starts to dance! Then they count the dance steps of the table, and form words out of them, also out of letters. These are spiritualistic sessions. What do people believe? They believe: Well, when we think, then nothing comes out of real knowledge; real knowledge must fall to us from somewhere. Now, in truth, it is so that the people who say that could certainly say it about themselves, because they are mostly those who are thoughtless and do not want to reflect, who would like the truth to come to them from somewhere without their own work. So eight of them sit around a table, then they have the table turned over, the first time A, the second time B, then C and so on, and from that they then form words – and those are then spiritualist revelations. Isn't that so, the wisdom came to them; they did not achieve it themselves!

But look, what should one actually say to such people? Such people want to recognize the spiritual world; that is their honest intention, to recognize the spiritual world. You cannot see the spirits; you cannot see or hear them because they have no body. So people think: they can use the table as a body, and in this way they can make themselves a little understood. Incidentally, it usually comes out as very general things that can be interpreted in different ways! But in any case, you have to say to these people: There you are, eight people sitting around the table; you want a spirit to come that makes itself heard. But aren't you spirits yourselves? You are spirits yourselves, sitting around there! Look at yourselves and seek the spirit within yourselves. There you will be able to find a much greater spirit. You will not assume that you will only be seen when you strike through a table, but when you use your limbs, your voices, and above all your powers of thought in a human way! Therefore it is indeed the case, and there is no need to doubt it, that when eight people sit around a table the table will begin to dance because the subconscious forces are acting on it. That is how it is, but it does not come out as something that would not come out in a much higher sense if a person were to exert his own Alpha or Aleph within himself.

But in the transition from Greek to Roman culture, people have forgotten Aleph. The first letter means A yes, only believe, the first letter means only A, that is, keep your mouth shut! But nothing comes of it. Once a wife got so fed up with her husband constantly lecturing from science. He had learned a lot and always lectured. She found it terribly annoying. And so one day she said to him: "You always want to lecture!" - "If you want to lecture, then shut up!" - Yes, actually the content has been completely lost. The Greeks did not think of one A, one Alpha, without thinking of the human being. They were immediately reminded of the human being. And they did not have a beta without remembering a house in which man lives. The alpha is always man. They imagined something similar to man. And at beta,

they imagined something that is around man. Then the Jewish Beth and the Greek beta became the envelope around the alpha, which is still inside as a spiritual being. In the same way, the body would be the Beth, the Beta, and the Alpha would be the spirit within. And now we speak of the “alphabet” - but for the Greeks this means: “man in his house”, or also: “man in his body”, in his covering.

Well, gentlemen, it is actually terribly funny. Take a dictionary in your hand today, then look up all the wisdom that mankind has in the alphabet. If someone - you won't do it - starts at A and stops at Z, then he would have all the wisdom in himself. Yes, but according to what can this wisdom be arranged in man? According to the alphabet, according to what can be known about the human being. It is very interesting: people have spread all wisdom because they no longer knew that it actually points to what comes from the alphabet. If you translate alphabet, it comes out, if you put it a little differently: human wisdom, human knowledge - again expressed with a Greek word: anthroposophy, human wisdom. And that is what every encyclopedia says. Actually, every encyclopedia should include anthroposophy, because it is only arranged according to the alphabet, according to human wisdom, “the human being in his body.” It is terribly funny: actually every encyclopedia represents a skeleton, where in the alphabetically arranged science the old wisdom has disappeared. All flesh and blood has gone, all the muscles and nerves have fallen away. Now go to the encyclopedia; it contains only the dead skeleton of the old science. Now a new science must arise that does not just have the dead skeleton, like the encyclopedia, but really has everything about the human being again, flesh and blood and so on: that is anthroposophy! Therefore, one would like to throw all these encyclopedias to the devil, although they are needed today, because they are the dead skeleton of an old science. A new science must be founded!

You see, gentlemen, that is what you can learn from the Sephiroth tree if you understand it in the right way. It was very useful of Mr. Dollinger to ask this question, because it has taken us a little deeper into anthroposophy.

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Lecture 8. 8 September 1910, Bern

It was said yesterday that through the Christ Event the two forms of Initiation became processes of world-historic significance, and when this is fully comprehended it epitomises an essential aspect of that Event.

One form of Initiation consisted in passing through the daily experience of waking from sleep in such a way that on penetrating into his physical and etheric bodies a man's faculties of perception were diverted from the physical environment and directed instead to the processes operating in those bodies. It was above all in the Mysteries and Mystery-centres of ancient Egypt that Initiation took this form. The aspirants were directed and guided in a way that enabled them to avoid the accompanying dangers; in a certain respect they became changed men, able during the process of Initiation to look into the spiritual world—to begin with into the sphere of spiritual forces and beings working in the human physical and etheric bodies.

The Essene Initiation may be described as follows.—When, having lived through the 42 stages, an Essene had gained more intimate knowledge of his inner nature, of his true Eg0-nature, and of what made spiritual vision possible when using the special organs transmitted by heredity, his consciousness was led beyond the 42 stages to awareness of the divine-spiritual Being who as Jahve, or Jehovah, had brought about the formation of the organ first possessed by Abraham; in the spirit the Essene became aware of the essential importance of this organ at that time. He was therefore looking back upon the structure of man's inner nature—itsself a product of the same divine-spiritual Being. Knowledge of man's inner nature was the aim of this Initiation.

In the lecture yesterday I spoke in a general sense of what is in store for one who penetrates into his own inner nature. In the first place, egoism in every shape and form is aroused, inducing a man to say to himself: I will marshal all the passions and emotions that are connected with my Ego and are averse from knowing anything of the spiritual world—I will marshal all these forces so that I can identify myself with them, acting and feeling only out of my own Ego-centric nature!—The danger is that a man who penetrates into his own inner nature may become supremely egoistic, and this also as a particular form of illusion to those who are endeavouring through esoteric development to achieve the same goal. In the latter case egoism takes many forms which the person in question usually does not recognize; in fact he believes his impulses to be the reverse of egoistic. Again and again it has been said that the path into the higher worlds demands inner conquests. But there are many who would like to tread this path without any such efforts, who would like to have vision of the higher worlds but are unwilling to undergo the experiences that make this possible; such people dislike having to overcome all kinds of impulses inherent in human nature and want to reach the higher worlds while at the same time avoiding all such impulses. They are quite unaware that to allow entirely regular and normal occurrences on this path to be the cause of disaffection is often a sign of extreme egoism. Every individual ought really to ask himself: Is it not inevitable that as a human being I should stir up powers of this kind?—But although it has been emphasized over and over again that at a certain stage something of the sort will happen, these people are still taken aback. In saying this I merely want to indicate the illusions and misconceptions to which everyone is apt to succumb. It must also be remembered that men in our time have become very ease-loving and would prefer to tread the path into the higher worlds with the comforts available to them in everyday life. But comforts much sought after in certain domains of life simply cannot be available along the path leading into the spiritual world.

In former times, a man who found this path through the process of Initiation which led into his inner nature, came into the realm of its own—divine-spiritual Powers at work in his physical and etheric bodies. Such a man was able to testify of the secrets of the spiritual world and to recount to his fellow-men the experiences undergone in the Mysteries while he was being led into his own inner nature and therewith into the spiritual world. But something was connected with this process. When the Initiate came back from the spiritual worlds he could say I have gazed into the realm of spiritual existence; but I was helped! The helpers of the Initiator made it possible for me to live through the time when the demonic beings from my own nature would have got the better of me.—But because he owed his vision of the spiritual world to helpers from outside, he remained dependent for the whole of his life upon this ‘Initiation-collegiate’, upon those who had been his helpers. He carried with him into the world the forces of the beings who had helped in his Initiation.

This was all to be changed and such dependence brought to an end. Aspirants for Initiation were to become less and less dependent upon those who were their teachers and initiators. For this help involved a factor of fundamental importance. In our everyday consciousness a clear and distinct feeling of ‘I’ awakens in us at a certain moment of our existence. This has often been spoken of, and my book *Theosophy* too refers to the point of time when the human being begins to be aware of himself as an ‘I’, an Ego—an experience that is not possible for an animal. If an animal were to look into its inner nature in the way a human being does, it would not find an individual Ego, but a group-Ego; it would feel itself belonging to a whole group. This feeling of egohood, was suppressed in the ancient Initiations while a man was rising into the spiritual worlds and from everything I have said you will realise that this was a beneficial measure. For all the individualistic impulses, passions and so forth which tend to separate man from the external world are bound up with the feeling of egohood. If passions and emotions were to be prevented from reaching a certain strength, it was necessary for the feeling of egohood to be dimmed. Consciousness during Initiations in the ancient Mysteries was not like that of dreams, but the feeling of egohood was suppressed. The goal now, since the Mystery of Golgotha, was that a man should undergo Initiation while maintaining full awareness of the Ego functioning in him during the hours of waking life. The clouding of the Ego that was always part of the process of ancient Initiation, was to cease. This, of course, can only come about gradually in the course of time, but in fact it has already been achieved to-day to a considerable extent in all rightly constituted Initiations; the feeling of egohood is not extinguished when a man rises into the higher worlds.

We will now study in greater detail an Initiation of pre-Christian times, for example, that of the Essenes. Suppression of the feeling of egohood was, in a certain sense, associated with this Initiation too. That which gives man the feeling of ‘I’, of egohood, in earthly existence, enabling him to have external perceptions—this had to be suppressed. You need think only of a very elementary aspect of everyday life to realise that in the different state of existence during sleep, when man is in the spiritual world, he has no consciousness of ‘I’. It is only in waking life that he has consciousness, when he has withdrawn from the spiritual world and his gaze is directed to the physical world of the

senses. So it is in men to-day and so too it was in those among whom Christ worked on the Earth. In a man belonging to the present era of Earth-existence the 'I' is not, in normal conditions, awake in the spiritual world. The essence of Christian Initiation, however, is that the 'I' remains fully awake in the higher worlds as in the external, physical world.

Think of the moment of waking. Man emerges from a higher world and descends into his physical and etheric bodies. At this moment, however, he does not become aware of the inner processes in these bodies because his faculty of perception is diverted to the environment. Now everything upon which man's gaze falls at the moment of waking, everything that comes within his purview—whether by physical perception through eyes or ears, or grasped with the intellect bound up with the physical organ of the brain—everything, in fact, that he perceives in the physical environment, was designated in the Hebraic secret doctrine as Malkhut,¹ the 'Kingdom'. This was the expression used for everything in which the 'I' of man could participate consciously. The most accurate rendering of what was conveyed in Hebraic antiquity by the expression the 'Kingdom', is this: That in which the human 'I' can be consciously present. Primarily, the Kingdom denoted the world of the senses, the world in which man lives in the waking condition with full Ego-consciousness.

Let us now follow the stages of ancient Initiation while a man was penetrating into his own inner nature. The first stage, before he could penetrate into his etheric body and become aware of its secrets, is not difficult to picture. As we know, the external sheaths of a human being consist of the astral body, the etheric body and the physical body. An aspirant for this kind of Initiation must be able consciously to see through his astral body as it were from within. He must first experience his astral body from within if he is to penetrate into the inner nature of his physical and etheric bodies. That is the portal through which he must pass. New, ever new, experiences await him—experiences as objective as those confronting him in the external world.

If we were to designate as the 'Kingdom' the objects which our present constitution enables us to perceive in our physical environment, we should distinguish three kingdoms: mineral, plant and animal. In the terminology of the ancient Hebrews no such definite distinction was made; the three kingdoms were comprised in one.

Just as we perceive the animals, plants and minerals through the Ego when we gaze into the world of the senses, so does the gaze of one in process of penetrating into his own inner nature fall upon everything that can be perceived in the astral body. Now, however, he does not perceive directly through his Ego; the Ego is using the instrument of the astral body. And what a man sees when using a different faculty of perception—that is, when his Ego is functioning in the world with which his astral organs connect him—was always designated in the language of the ancient Hebrews by three expressions. Just as we have an animal kingdom, a plant kingdom and a mineral kingdom, the trinity perceived when a man's consciousness was functioning in his astral body was designated by three words: Netzah, Yesod and Hod.

To translate these expressions into our language with any degree of accuracy it would be necessary to probe deeply into the feeling for words that existed in ancient Hebraic culture, for the renderings usually given in dictionaries do not help at all. For example, Hod as a combination of sounds would have conveyed the meaning of 'spirit revealing itself outwardly.' The word would have signified spirituality manifesting itself outwardly, striving to express itself outwardly, but spirituality that must be conceived of as astral. The word Netzah would have been the term denoting this urge for outward expression in a much denser form. The word 'impermeable' may perhaps convey some indication of the meaning.

In modern textbooks of Physics you will find a statement that should really count as a definition only, but logic has not been taken into consideration. It is said that physical bodies are 'impermeable'; but the definition of a physical body ought in reality to be that at the place where it is, no other body can be at the same time. This should count as a definition, but instead of that a dogma is created, and it is said: bodies of the physical world have the quality of impermeability—whereas the correct phraseology would be that two bodies cannot be at the same place simultaneously. That, however, is a matter belonging to philosophy. Self-manifestation in space so that everything else is excluded was expressed by the word Netzah—this would be a much denser nuance of Hod. What lies between the two was indicated by the word Yesod.

Thus there are three different nuances. First, an astral reality revealing itself outwardly—Hod; when densification or coarsening has occurred to such a degree that things become physically impermeable, the Hebraic term would have

been Netzah; Yesod indicated the intermediate degrees. It may therefore be said that these three words designated the three different qualities or attributes of the beings of the astral world.

We can now follow the experiences of the aspirant for Initiation through the further stages leading into his inner nature. Having first passed through the necessary stages in his astral body, he penetrated into his etheric body, where he became aware of realities higher than those designated by these three words. Why higher?—you may ask. There is a particular reason for this—one of which account must be taken if you want to understand the inner structure of the world and of man. You must remember that it is the very highest spiritual forces that have worked on what appear to us as the lowest manifestations of the external world. Your attention has often been drawn to this, especially in connection with the nature and constitution of man.

We describe man as consisting of physical body, etheric body, astral body and Ego. The Ego or 'I' of man is in a certain sense the highest of his members; but at the stage at which it is to-day, it is the 'baby' among the four. At present the 'I' is actually at the lowest stage, yet it contains the rudiments of the highest perfection attainable by man. On the other hand, the physical body is, in its way, the most perfect member—although this is due, not to man himself but to the work performed by divine-spiritual Beings through the evolutionary epochs of Old Saturn, Old Sun and Old Moon. The astral body too has already reached a stage of greater perfection than that of the Ego. The Ego is the member of our being with which we identify ourselves. Anyone who does not deliberately close his eyes to reality need only look within himself to find his Ego. On the other hand, just think how far man is from understanding the mysteries of his physical body! Divine-spiritual Beings have been working at the human physical body not for millions of years only but for millions upon millions to perfect its present structure. Between physical body and Ego are the astral body and the etheric body. Compared with the physical body, the astral body is an imperfect member, having within it desires, passions, emotions and so forth. Owing to the forces and nature of the astral body man enjoys many things that are directly injurious to the constitution of the physical body, although the etheric body, lying between them, acts as a check. Man enjoys many things that are poison for the heart; if he depended on the astral body alone his health would very soon be undermined. He owes his health entirely to the fact that the human heart is so perfectly constructed that it is able for many decades to withstand the attacks of the astral body. The more deeply we penetrate into man's constitution, the higher are the spiritual forces that have worked at its members. It could be said that our 'I' has been bestowed upon us by the youngest gods, the youngest divine-spiritual Powers; and much older gods have produced in our lower members that perfection which man today hardly even begins to comprehend; still less is he capable of producing with the instruments at his disposal the marvellous structure created by the divine-spiritual Beings.

This perfection was perceived and experienced in a very special sense by those who through an Essene Initiation, for example, penetrated into the inner regions of man's being. An Essene Initiate said to himself: When I have completed the first fourteen stages I pass into my astral body; there I am confronted by all the passions and emotions associated with it, by whatever harm I have done to my astral body during my incarnation. But I have not yet been able to do as much injury to my etheric body as to my astral body. My etheric body is still much more godlike, much purer; it reveals itself to me when I am passing through the second fourteen stages.—And he had the feeling that having resisted the attacks of his astral body, he had overcome the greatest stumbling-block connected with the first fourteen stages and had now passed into the light-filled spheres of his etheric body, the forces of which he had not yet been able to injure to a like extent.

What a man beheld at this second stage was indicated in the secret doctrine of the ancient Hebrews by three expressions, all of which are extremely difficult to render in our modern language. The three expressions were Gedulah (or Hesed), Tipheret, Geburah. Let us try to picture the three realms of experience designated by these words.

When a man became aware of the realities revealed to him in his etheric body, the effect expressed by the first word, Gedulah was a picture, a conception, of majesty and grandeur in the spiritual world, of everything that gives the impression of overwhelming power. On the other hand, the word Geburah, although related to Gedulah, expressed a quite different nuance of greatness—greatness deprived of a certain quality through activity. Geburah expressed that nuance of greatness, of power, which manifests outwardly in order to project itself, to assert itself in the outer world as an independent force. Whereas the expression 'Gedulah' implied that the effect produced was due to intrinsic excellence, Geburah conveyed the impression of a kind of aggressiveness, of something asserting itself outwardly through aggressive behaviour. Tipheret was the word used to designate greatness at rest within itself, inner richness which manifests outwardly but without any element of aggressiveness, giving expression to spiritual greatness through

its own nature. To convey what was implied by this word would only be possible by combining our two concepts of Goodness and Beauty. A being bringing its inner richness to expression in its outer form appears beautiful to us; and a being bringing its own intrinsic excellence to expression outwardly, appears good to us. But in the secret doctrine of the ancient Hebrews these two concepts belong together—as Tipheret.—Thus it was by penetrating into his etheric body that a man came into contact with beings expressing themselves through these three qualities.

The next stage was the penetration into the physical body. Here a man came to know the most ancient among the divine-spiritual Beings who have worked at his creation. Remind yourselves that in the articles contained in the book *From the Akashic Chronicle*² and in *Occult Science—an Outline*, it was said that the very first rudiment of the human physical body came into existence on Old Saturn. Very sublime spiritual Beings, the Thrones, sacrificed their own will-substance in order that the first rudiment of man's physical body might arise; and sublime spiritual Beings worked on this rudiment during the further course of evolution through the Saturn, Sun and Moon evolutions. In the lectures on Genesis, given in Munich, I described how these lofty spiritual Beings continued their work through these earlier periods, organising and elaborating this rudiment of the human physical body to higher and higher stages, culminating in the marvellous physical organism in which the human being, consisting of etheric body, astral body and Ego can incarnate to-day.

When a man was able to penetrate into his inmost nature he became aware of what was described in the Hebraic secret teachings as the embodiment of qualities only to be conceived of by reflecting on the very highest wisdom attainable by the human soul. Man regards wisdom as an ideal; he feels lifted to a higher level when he can imbue any part of himself with wisdom. Those (among the Essenes) whose consciousness penetrated into the physical body knew that they were now approaching Beings whose very nature and substance consisted of what can be acquired by man in a very small measure only, when he strives for wisdom not attained through acts of ordinary cognition but through hard and heavy experiences of the soul, gained only in the course of many incarnations. Even then only a certain amount of wisdom is acquired; for not until it has been sought in every possible form could anyone be said to possess it fully. At this stage of Initiation an Essene became aware of Beings revealing themselves as Beings of Wisdom, Beings whose intrinsic quality manifested itself as pure, awe-inspiring wisdom.. This quality was expressed in the secret doctrine of the ancient Hebrews by the word Hokhmah, rendered to-day as ‘Wisdom’.

A particular nuance of this attribute or quality of wisdom is again a certain densification. This is present in man but in his individuality he acquires it to a small extent only. On penetrating into the physical body from within, however, a man again encounters Beings who possess this quality—it is a densification of wisdom—in such a marked degree that it seems literally to radiate from them. It is the quality expressed by the word Binah in the secret doctrine of the ancient Hebrews, and is akin to what can be evoked in man his reason is called into play. Man acquires the power of reason to a certain limited degree only. But when the word Binah is used we must think of Beings entirely permeated by what can be born of reason. Binah is a denser nuance of Hokhmah. Hence when reference was made in the Hebraic secret doctrine to the original creative Wisdom out of which worlds were born, Hokhmah was compared to a spring of water, and Binah to a sea—indicating a certain degree of densification.

And the very loftiest experience attainable through penetration into the physical body was designated by the word Keter. It is almost impossible to find an adequate translation for this word. The quality which conveyed an inkling of the attributes of divine-spiritual Beings of the greatest sublimity could only be indicated by a symbol expressing the fact that a man was raised above his own level, invested with a significance greater than was normally his. The expression designating the lofty nature of this quality was Keter, ‘Crown’.

Binah	Chochmah	Kether
Geburah	Tiphereth	Gedulah (or Hesed)
Nezach	Jesod	Hod
Malchuth, the Kingdom, Ego		

The following, then, are the qualities or attributes of the Beings whose realm a man reaches when he penetrates within himself into his own inner nature.³ You can picture to yourselves that in an Essene Initiation entirely new experiences were undergone by a man, when the qualities and attributes referred to became realities to him.

How did an Essene Initiation contrast with the character and form of Initiation enacted among the neighbouring peoples?

All ancient Initiations were adapted to cause the suppression of the feeling of 'I' that a man has when he is gazing at Malkhut, the Kingdom. The feeling of 'I' was to be eliminated. Hence in Initiation a man could not be as he was in the physical world. True, he was led upwards into the spiritual world, but as an Initiate he could not be man in the sense that he was man in the Kingdom, in Malkhut. In connection with ancient Initiations, therefore, a sharp distinction was made between what a man experienced as an Initiate on the one hand and within his Ego on the other.

If one wanted to give a brief indication of the conditions attaching to Initiation in the secret schools of ancient times compared with those obtaining in public life, one would have to say the following.—Let nobody believe that he can retain the same feeling of egohood that he has in the Kingdom, in Malkhut, if he aspires to become an Initiate. Wonderful and glorious experiences of I lie three times three attributes in their reality come to him as he reaches higher and higher stages; but he must entirely discard the feeling of egohood that is his in the external world. Experiences designated by the words Netzah, Yesod, Hod, and so forth, cannot be carried down into Malkhut, cannot remain associated with man's ordinary feeling of egohood. That was the conviction held universally. And anyone who might have dared to contradict this principle in ancient times would have been regarded as a fool, a madman and a liar.

The Essenes were the first to teach that the time would come when everything that is above would be carried down, so that man would be able to experience it while maintaining his feeling of egohood intact. The Greeks spoke of Βασιλεια του οπου (the Kingdoms of Heaven). It was the Essenes who first taught of the coming of One who would bring down for the 'I', for the Ego living in Malkhut, what is above in the 'Kingdoms of Heaven.' And this too was taught in words of awe-inspiring power by Jeschu ben Pandira to the Essenes and to a few of those around him. The gist of his teaching as transmitted in the immediate future through his pupil Mathai (Matthew) may be indicated briefly in the following way.—

Inspired as he was by the successor of Gautama Buddha, by the Bodhisattva who will eventually become the Maitreya Buddha, Jeschu ben Pandira taught to this effect.—Hitherto the Kingdoms of Heaven could not be brought down into Malkhut, into the realm to which the Ego of man belongs. But when the three times fourteen generations have taken their course and the time is thus fulfilled, there will be born from the progeny of Abraham, from the stem of David, the stem of Jesse (Jessians=Essenes), One who will bring the nine attributes of the Kingdoms of Heaven into the realm in which the 'I' of man is actively present.—This teaching led to Jeschu ben Pandira being stoned as a blasphemer, for it was held to be the grossest violation of the principles of Initiation by those who refused to admit or to recognise that because humanity progresses, something that is right for one period is not necessarily right for another.

Then came the time when prophecy was fulfilled, when the three times fourteen generations had run their course and when there could arise from the blood of the people a bodily constitution in which Zarathustra was able to incarnate, and subsequently, having achieved further development by the means available in the body of the Nathan Jesus, to offer up that body to the Christ.⁴ The time had come of which Christ's forerunner had declared that the Kingdoms of Heaven would draw near to the Ego which lives in the external world, in Malkhut.

We shall now realise the nature of the task facing Christ after the Temptation. He had withstood the Temptation through the power of His own being, through the principle which in a man to-day, we call the 'I', the Ego. He had been victorious over all the attacks and temptations confronting one who penetrates into his own astral, etheric and physical bodies. This is clearly shown in the story. Egoism in all forms is present in such a way as to reveal it in its greatest possible intensity.

A stubborn factor arising in one who is striving for esoteric development is the tendency to occupy himself solely with his own personality. It is precisely in those who want to find their way into the spiritual world that the habit is so often found of loving to talk about their own cherished personality, concerning themselves with it every moment of the day. Whereas in other circumstances people may deliberately refrain from adopting this attitude when they make efforts to develop or perhaps when they first become anthroposophists, they now begin to pay great attention to their own Ego; and then illusions arise on all hands, illusions from which they were formerly diverted by the ordinary demands of life.

Why does this happen? It is because such people are incapable of coping with what rises up from their own inner nature. They are utterly at a loss to know how to deal with what is happening in themselves. Formerly they were alert and readily attracted by the external world; now they are diverted to their own inner world and all sorts of feelings and emotions that were within them begin to rise up. Why is this? What such a person really wants is to be an Ego, entirely independent of the external world. But then he often falls into the error of wanting to be treated like a child who is told clearly what he must do. He wants to be anything rather than a man who sets his own direction and aim in accordance with what esoteric life teaches him. He has not yet begun to reflect about it, but he has the feeling that dependence upon the external world is a disturbing factor, especially when he wants to be absolutely untrammelled and give all his attention to the dictates of his own egoism. But there is one fact, trivial though it may seem, that prevents him from detaching his bodily life at least from the surrounding world; this fact is that human beings are obliged to eat! It is a trivial fact but it is fatally true. We can learn from it how powerless we are without the world around us. It is a trenchant example of our dependence upon the surrounding world without which we could not live; we are really like a finger on our hand: if we cut it off it withers. A quite trivial consideration can therefore show us the extent to which we are dependent upon the surrounding world.

Egoism at its highest pitch may take the form of the wish: If only I could become independent of the surrounding world; if only I were myself capable of conjuring into existence by magic that which as an ordinary human being I need in physical life but which causes me to be so strongly aware of my dependence upon the world around! Such a wish may actually arise in those who are seeking to attain Initiation. Even hatred may be aroused by the realisation that one is dependent on the environment and incapable of conjuring the means of nourishment into existence by magic. It seems strange to say this, but although wishes that soon arise on a small scale when a person is striving to develop, appear paradoxical, in their extreme form they become downright absurdity. A man is usually quite unaware that he has such wishes. In point of fact no human being has them so strongly that he is deluded into claiming the power to create food by magic, to sustain life by something not derived from the external world, from Malkhut. But in an extreme case someone might believe: If only I were able to live so entirely in my astral body and Ego that I could rely for my needs entirely on my own wishes, I should no longer be dependent on the surrounding world!

This form of temptation does arise. And in the case of the One who was to undergo it in its greatest intensity, it is characterized by the saying that the Tempter confronting Christ Jesus bade Him turn stones into bread. This is temptation in its extreme form. The descent into a man's own inner being is described most wonderfully in St. Matthew's story of the Temptation.

The second stage comes after the aspirant for Initiation has penetrated into his astral body and is confronted by all the emotions and passions that could have made him into an utter egoist. Perceiving all this, instead of resisting and overcoming it, a man would like to cast himself down into the etheric body and physical body. This is a situation that may well be described as hurling oneself into the abyss. And this is how it is actually described in St. Matthew's Gospel: man casts himself down into what he has not hitherto been able to spoil to any considerable extent—namely, the etheric and physical bodies. But the passions and emotions must first have been overcome. The Christ Being knows this and facing the Tempter, having overcome the forces by His own power, declares: Thou shalt not tempt the Being to whom thou shouldst not surrender thyself !

Then comes the third stage—the penetration into the physical body. When this descent into the physical and etheric bodies takes the form of temptation, it is an experience that may come to every human being during the process of Initiation at the stage when he sees himself from within. He then perceives everything that is contained in the three highest attributes. This is like a world to him but, to begin with, a world of illusion only, a world he cannot see as intrinsic truth unless he penetrates through the sheath of the physical body and rises to those spiritual Beings who are not themselves actually within the physical body but only work in it. If we do not rid ourselves of egoism it is always the tempter of the physical world, Lucifer or Diabolus, who wishes to deceive us about our own being. He promises us everything that confronts us—although it is merely the product of our own maya, our own illusion. If this spirit of egoism does not leave us, we behold a whole world, but a world of deception and lies. Lucifer promises us this world. Let us not believe it to be a world of truth! We enter this world but remain in maya if we do not eventually free ourselves from it.

The Christ Being lived through these three stages of temptation before the eyes of mankind as a model and an example to be followed. Inasmuch as the Temptation was once undergone outside the sanctuaries of the Mysteries, resisted

through the power of a Being indwelling the three human sheaths, the impulse was given whereby it was made possible for man in the future course of evolution to rise into the spiritual world with the 'I'-consciousness belonging to the external realm of Malkhut. The two worlds were no longer to be separate and man was to be capable of rising into the spiritual worlds with the 'I' that lives in Malkhut. This was achieved for humanity through the victory over the Temptation as related in the Gospel of St. Matthew. A Being living on the Earth had now provided the model for the ascent of the human 'I' from the kingdom of Malkhut into the higher worlds and realms of existence.

What was the result of the Christ Being having lived through as an historical event, an experience hitherto undergone only in the secrecy of the Mysteries? The natural result was the preaching of the Kingdom. The Gospel of St. Matthew therefore relates the Temptation first and then proceeds to describe the stages of the ascent of the Ego, the 'I', that henceforth will be able in itself consciously to experience the spiritual world. The secret of the 'I' that in accordance with the mode of consciousness prevailing in the external world rises into the spiritual word—this secret, as the Gospel of St. Matthew relates, was now to be unveiled through the Christ Being during the time following the Temptation. Then come the chapters beginning with the Sermon on the Mount and therewith presenting the conception given by Christ of the Kingdom, of Malkhut.

Such are the profundities to be fathomed in the Gospel of St. Matthew. The sources and basic elements of this Gospel must be sought in the secret teachings not only of the Essenes but in those existing in the whole world of ancient Hebraic and Greek culture. We then feel for such a text the profound reverence which, as was said in the Munich lectures,⁵ arises when, enriched with the findings of spiritual-scientific investigation, we turn to the records bequeathed to us by the seers of olden time. We feel that such records speak to us across the ages. It is as though a spirit-language in which great Individualities converse with one another through the centuries were becoming audible—audible, of course, only to those who understand the words of the Gospel: 'He who hath ears to hear, let him hear!' But just as in the remote past many things had to happen in order that physical ears might become part of our organism, so it is in the case of the spiritual ears through which we comprehend what is said in those great spiritual records.

The purpose of modern Spiritual Science is to enable us to read and decipher these spiritual records. Not until we have acquired insight into the true nature of the in the Kingdom, in Malkhut, shall we be able to understand the chapter in St. Matthew's Gospel beginning: Blessed are they who are beggars for the Spirit; for through themselves, through their own Ego, they shall find the Kingdoms of Heaven! An Initiate of ancient times would have said to a man: In your own Ego you search in vain for the Kingdoms of Heaven. But Christ Jesus said: The time has come when in their own Egos men will find the Spirit when they seek the Kingdoms of Heaven.

The historic Christ Event consists in the carrying of profound Mystery-secrets into the external world. In this sense we shall be studying that Event still more closely, and then you will understand how to interpret the Beatitudes in the Sermon on the Mount.

GA123

GA096

The Lord's Prayer: An Esoteric Study, Prayer and Meditation

Lecture 1. 28 January 1907, Berlin



When the will has reached a level where it is capable of performing ‘the great sacrifice’, as it is called, then it makes, it creates a universe, large or small, and this universe is a mirror image that has been given its mission through the essential nature of its creator. We have thus characterized the creative will in the divine spirit.

The second principle we have to characterize in divine nature, in so far as it has entered into humanity, is already contained in the analogy we have made—it is the mirror image itself. Enter as actively as you can into a divine spirit that is the creator of a world and the centre of the universe. If you think of a point in this room and imagine that rather than by these walls, of which there are six, it is surrounded by a hollow sphere, the inner surface of which is a mirror, you will see yourself, the centre, reflected on all sides. You have the image of a divine spirit as a will centre that is reflected on all sides, and the mirror is the image of the godhead itself and also of the universe. For what is a universe? It is nothing but a mirror reflecting the essential nature of the divine spirit.

The universe is alive and active. And this is because the godhead emanates in making its great sacrifice, in reflecting its universe, which is like the enlivening of the mirror image we tried to imagine. The whole universe is given life out of the universal will that comes to expression in infinite variety. This process of infinite variety, infinite replication, this repetition of the godhead is known as the ‘realm’, as distinct from the ‘will’, in every occult or spiritual science. The will is thus the centre; its mirror is the realm, so that you may compare the will with atman or spirit man, and the realm, or mirror image of the will, with buddhi or life spirit.

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realm, so that you may compare the will with atman or spirit man, and the realm, or mirror image of the will, with buddhi or life spirit.

Now this realm is such that it reflects the essential nature of the divine in infinite variety. Just look at this realm all around, in so far as it is our realm, our rich variety, our universe; look at its visible part in minerals, plants, animals and human beings. The realm manifests in every individual form, and something of this still lives on in the German term Reich [meaning 'rich' as well as 'realm'; tr.], with the major divisions of our universe called the mineral, plant and animal worlds or realms. But if we also go into detail, then every detail, too, is divine by nature. Nature is reflected in all of it, just as the centre would be mirrored in the hollow sphere. And someone who looks at the world in the terms of occult research sees the god, an image and expression of the divine, in every mineral, every plant, every animal and every human being.

The divine spirit shows itself in infinitely many different forms of life in all their variety. If one has reached the level of perception in the science of the spirit that enables one to see the individual entities as having originated in the godhead, they are told apart by giving them a 'name'. It is the name which the human being thinks of as the individual entity; it serves to distinguish the individual entities in this vast variety from one another. It is the third of the greatest three human principles that flow from the godhead and may be said to correspond to the manas or spirit self. The occult teaching of different religions also used to teach, naively, what had flowed from the godhead and flowed into you, becoming your eternal image.

If you wish to rise to the realm to which you are ultimately destined to rise, you will find that it is will-like by nature.

If you wish to rise to the buddhi, the bearer of this will, of this atman, its realm is of the divine.

And if you wish to rise to that which you perceive to be names, concepts or ideas of things—this is what name is within the realm of the divine.

What we have been considering is the ancient wisdom which tells us that name, realm and will make up the part of the godhead that has flowed into essential human nature to be the eternal part of it. We thus see that the three higher principles in man are part of the divine.

Wenn der Wille auf solcher Stufe angelangt ist, daß er zu vollbringen imstande ist, was man das große Opfer nennt, dann schafft, schöpft er ein Universum, groß oder klein, und dieses Universum ist ein Spiegelbild, das seine Aufgabe durch das Wesen des Schöpfers selbst bekommt. Dadurch haben wir charakterisiert, was der schöpferische Wille in der göttlichen Wesenheit ist.